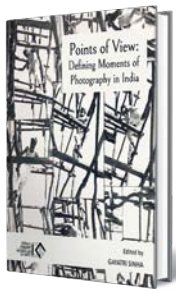
PHOTOGRAPHY

THE BIG INDIA PICTURE

As they move from the tripod to the selfie, two new volumes shed much light on the practice of ***Indian photography*** *and theories that have informed it*



POINTS OF VIEW: Defining Moments of Photography in India, Volume 1
by Gayatri Sinha (Editor)
KIRAN NADAR MUSEUM OF ART
₹4,700; 387 pages

These twinned volumes are intended as a comprehensive overview of Indian photography from the inception of the medium to our current time. In this they succeed, covering the subject like those large black drapes covering both photographer and view camera. As with the drapes, there are holes and pinpricks, but these don't interfere with the larger picture.

The *Points of View* volume comprises an introduction and 15 essays, all copiously illustrated, that examine different situations through which photography arrived and spread in the subcontinent, creating an ecosystem of imagery that was globally recognisable yet completely unique. As Gayatri Sinha argues in her introduction, the aim is not encyclopaedic but rather to ask the question: "...does photography (in India) enable new relationships, both mediatic and cultural, and create new generative capacities?"

The *Archival Gaze* volume is meant to be read side by side with its sibling and it works differently: opening it, you are plunged into a procession of images that is chronological but not strictly so; alongside, the text takes us through 1840–2020 in sections of two decades, marking important events in the development and diversification of photography in the region. There are many more large reproductions here, and the invitation is to look first, moving back and forth between different photographs, and to search for the textual moorings later.

Through these books you can explore the riverine progression of light-based image making its way across the land. The large tripoded contraption is first seen being used by a few Europeans in the mid-19th century; soon, a couple of Maharajahs have procured the elaborate paraphernalia and become highly skilled exponents; by the end of the 19th century a wide assortment of the bourgeoisie is using the medium for all sorts of purposes. Across this period, a certain 'India' begins to be produced—visually manufactured—by *gora* and native photographers: ancient buildings, ruins, sculptures and artefacts, landscapes, portraits of royalty and commoners, objects of daily use, all of these made somehow more 'real' by being rendered in monochromatic frames. Through this, a certain composite portrait, an Orientalist identikit of India and Indian culture coalesces for the world; and this is then glanced back to those Indians who have access to photographs and photo-books.

As the essays lay out, the image traffic is hardly one-way: while the subcontinent

You are plunged into a **PROCESSION OF IMAGES** that is chronological but not strictly so. The text takes us through 1840-2020, marking key events in the development of Indian photography





